

*Research to inform policy from the University of York*

## **The Digital Divide: The Lived Experience of Ethnic Minority and Marginalised Communities in York**

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*This preliminary study provides a deep dive into how the 'digital divide' is currently being experienced by minority and marginalised communities: homeless, recovering, refugee, Traveller, Islamic and economically deprived, within the City of York, UK. Exploring themes of definition, lived experience, needs, and existing initiatives, insights into the impact of this on individuals – adults and children – and households are provided along with community-led priorities and innovation*

*. Key findings and recommendations are provided, and it is expected that this analysis will provide a useful input for policy makers when setting priorities and designing strategies to ensure digital inclusion, while opening up this topic up for discussion and further research.*

*NOTE: In response to the COVID-19 pandemic, a national review into the digital divide, particular data affordability, was commissioned and published by the National Lottery Local Trust. The findings presented here align with and support those of this larger study and it is recommended that the two are read together:*

*[Making Connections: Community-led action on data poverty \(2021\)](#)*

## **INTRODUCTION**

This study was undertaken during June and July 2021, to gain an insight into the current lived experience of digital exclusion within minority and marginalised communities of York, UK.

Data for this study was collected via interviews with eight community leaders, mentors and front-line support staff and volunteers currently working within ethnic minority, displaced, homeless and deprived communities. Many of these participants are or were also members of these communities and therefore have first-hand experience and a deep understanding of digital exclusion. In addition to these interviews, the opportunity was taken to pose questions at two regular group events: an online adult, female learning group and a community 'pay as you feel' meal.

All data collected has been anonymised using pseudonyms and analysed thematically. The findings, presented below, have been organised under the overarching themes of: Definitions, Lived Experience and Looking Forward. Naturally, lived experiences during the current COVID-19 pandemic feature prominently in this study.

## KEY FINDINGS AND RECOMMENDATIONS

- **COMMUNITY BASED, LED AND COLLABORATIVE:**

Participants felt that, given the variability in digital skills in the ethnic minority and marginalised communities they serve and their innate vulnerability, they are best placed to identify instances of digital exclusion and determine the type of support needed. However, it was also felt that to be truly effective, this must be delivered through collaboration between themselves, and between them as a group and the Local Authority. A network underpinned by the ethos that an individual connected to one, was connected to all.

- **CENTRALISED EXPERTISE AND SUPPORT:**

Participants, often members of the community they serve, acknowledged that their own digital knowledge and skills had limits and that it was difficult if not impossible to keep up with the rapidly changing digital world. They all felt that they would benefit from access to dedicated, expert central resources providing timely and consistent advice.

- **CO-DESIGNED SERVICES AND SUPPORT:**

Participants shared their frustrations with 'digital first' strategies, especially in relation to essential State services such as Universal Credit and Housing. Central to this is the remote development of processes and systems which do not consider the specific needs and limitations of ethnic minority and marginalised communities. Many already provide cultural competency education and would welcome the opportunity to co-design services and support programmes.

- **WHOLE-LIFE APPROACH:**

Participants acknowledged that the development of digital skills could and should not be separated from the development of wider life skills; managing personal finances and budgeting being key to affordability, as strong risk assessment skills are to online safety. Their experiences showed that the best outcomes were achieved by taking whole-life approaches, tailored to the individual but taking into consideration the wider family/household situation.

- **SIGNIFICANT, LONG-TERM COMMITMENT:**

Participants explained that for some members of their community complex issues and intersectionality may prevent or restrict levels of digital inclusion requiring on-going assisted access and/or support just to maintain current digital competencies. However, it was strongly felt that this should not constrain the potential of, or opportunities for, the community as a whole and that long term development programmes are required to provide the advanced digital knowledge and skills demanded by today's workplaces.

## DEFINITIONS

To determine the overall scale and scope of digital exclusion within the boundaries of this study, all participants were asked the same opening question “How would you define the digital divide?”

At its highest level, all participants defined the digital divide as a form of ‘access deficit’ often but not always or indeed explicitly referring to online access (the internet and web). Using diverse terms such as: ‘*exclusion*’, ‘*difficulty*’ and ‘*deprivation*’ in their definitions participants demonstrated, perhaps unconsciously, how broad and multifaceted the nature and impact of the digital divide is.

***Maria:** When I think of digital divide, its more like those who can't, for whatever reason, use this facility [computers and the internet] and kind of are deprived or even depriving themselves because of some kind of fear and those who are able to use it robustly and well and make use of it.*

There was also a clear recognition that while overall affordability was a recurring theme, a situation exasperated in a city like York where, as Sarah explained “*There's a different demographic around this area that is low income in York and York's expensive to live*”, there is no single, underlying cause of digital exclusion nor is there a direct link between specific issues and specific ethnic minority and marginalised communities.

The impacts of digital exclusion: poorer health outcomes, increased loneliness and social isolation, less access to jobs and education, paying more for essentials and increased risk of poverty ([Good Things Foundation](#)) were touched on by all participants and while the impacts are extensive all also noted the varying levels of digital access needs, capacity and capability, of individuals and households, within their communities. Most noted having members who were highly proficient in the use of digital technology, one notable example being a refugee family where the father has a PhD in Physics and the mother previously worked in a bank versus those who they felt were totally excluded.

***Vanessa:** We had one client that went two months without benefits because he kept coming to our door waiting for us to open, we'd put a sign on the door saying we were closed and to ring us or to email us, but he couldn't read it. So he just kept coming back every other day. We found that out about two months in that he was doing that and to me, that's complete exclusion.*

***Paul:** I've just come across a family who have been under the radar their whole lives. Dad's tipping 80, son with a learning disability in his mid-50s so they really struggle at this point [during the pandemic restrictions]. There's a lot else going on that we've just found him essentially. So yeah, to talk talking about WiFi on computers is just inappropriate.*

Neither did participants view digital exclusion as being limited to particular devices such as smartphones, tablets or laptops (PCs) or specific uses such as information, entertainment or ecommerce but rather as online (internet/web) access irrespective of device used nor that the situation is not one of simply 'have' versus 'have not'. Overnight, COVID-19 forced not just consideration of the 'digital individual' but the 'digital household', where access to devices and the internet may be available but not at a level to sufficiently support the whole household in living, working and studying at home.

*Ali: I think it means not being able to access the internet, or have the same resources as everyone [else] in like, computers, and Zoom ... it's access to digital technology and not just whether or not you have a laptop, but whether you've got enough for everyone there, whether people are trained in how they use it, whether they're able to use it in their first language. And yeah, I think that feeling of being excluded during COVID, from events, from education, from lots of social aspects as well.*

Participants appreciated that the digital realm is continuously evolving both in terms of technological capability and capacity and the increasing integration of technology into everyday life. As one participant, Maria, noted using the example of analogue telephones, current conversations around internet enabled devices and online access are only the latest in a long history of technology driven exclusion and for Kyle, even this conversation was seriously limited and outdated:

*Kyle: I think that's the other thing that we're kind of conscious of is when people talk about digital exclusion, they talk about it within the context of digital technology 10 years ago, so it they don't talk about the kind of integrated technologies that seems to be, you know, much more prevalent these days.*

## LIVED EXPERIENCE

### ACCESSIBILITY: DEVICES & DATA

There was an opportunity, as part of this study, to pose a simple question to residents of what is regarded as a deprived neighbourhood while they queued at a 'pay-as-you-feel' community lunch. The question asked was "Which of the following do you have access to at home?" with the multiple choice answers: Computer, Mobile Phone and Internet. A total of 51 people answered the question and while 86% of respondents (44 people) had access to a mobile phone, only 39% (20 people) had access to all three and 8% (4 people) did not have access to any of these at home.

## Affordability

Although it cannot be said for certain that affordability was the reason that 8% of respondents in the 'queue question' results as other variables including personal choice (discussed further below) prevent individuals from engaging, considering these results in conjunction with participant interviews, affordability was the main issue associated with devices and data.

All participants knew of individuals, especially very marginalised people such as the elderly or asylum seekers and refugees, who could not afford to buy a smartphone, tablet etc although they felt that this was not necessarily problematic, and therefore visible, until the social restrictions of the COVID-19 pandemic moved the majority of everyday activities online. They also noted that schools had moved quickly to provide laptops to children without any other means to access the internet and access online teaching.

Schemes for donated devices also came up in conversation and it was felt that, while kindly meant, such devices, even when reconditioned, are rarely of a sufficient specification to support increasingly large applications and web services which require significant processing power and memory to run successfully.

Several participants discussed providing their staff and volunteers with smartphones and/or Laptops, only one participant, Paul, highlighted that his organisation had a stock of devices, smartphone including three months of pre-paid data, which were given out to people to combat isolation and "so they could manage their journal for benefits and things like that".

However, he was concerned over the sustainability of such initiatives, specifically in terms of long term affordability, and that after the period of providing effectively free data the recipient would be *"left with a new outgoing or something to pay ... then what are we doing, are we just teasing them with a phone for three months, and then it's no longer usable?"*.

He further noted that in this situation he and his team would probably provide information and support around the larger but related issue of managing personal finances including budgeting and other participants noted similar, albeit ad hoc, training sessions. This echoes the Good Things Foundation conclusions in their work on [Digital Divide: Work and Jobs](#); specifically that digital and financial inclusion are inextricably linked and highlighting the need to consider digital inclusion within a wider contexts of individual, household and even community circumstances and constraints. As emphasised by another participant: *"One member of the family might go into debt on broadband and [this] effects the whole household"*.

Looking at accessibility issues from the point of view of a logical sequence, the obvious starting point is the lack of physical equipment devices, peripherals, WIFI routers however data affordability is arguably a greater issue and had been for at least ten years. Several participants noted how, especially during COVID-19 people, and especially children, needed to connect to local, free WiFi services to be able to shop, work and study.

**Vanessa:** ... the kids on the site during lockdown some of them got laptops and tablets to use, but they have no Wi Fi. So the school gave them and expected them to keep up with their schoolwork on these things but one kid told me that she used to walk to the edge of the site and sit on the end of the site gate to be able to access the free Wi Fi from the city.

**Sarah:** I have no idea how then people would have coped [without home broadband/WiFi] because there was no access. We found a lot of children, hanging around the building [community centre/library] even though it was closed, because of the WiFi access.

## Understanding & Confidence

Considering reasons for none or low digital engagement other than affordability, two clear themes ran through participant comments: a foundation understanding of personal technology (in general) and being able to confidently resolve unexpected situations such as errors, updates or viruses and other types of malware.

To participants it was clear that a basic level of knowledge is missing. As Vanessa stated “... from our clients’ point of view, it was the lack of understanding of how all this stuff works was the first point”. This point was repeated by Andrea who also noted “... people on WiFi not knowing the difference between WiFi and broadband, or strength, or cost and often older people get put on by the youngsters [and] they don't realise once you've paid for your broadband, that you can contact someone for nothing”.

People do not understand how the internet, ‘cloud computing’ and connected devices work in terms of both the physical equipment and infrastructure but also the associated responsibilities of ownership and use, and the different services and costs associated with using these. For several participants, this was directly linked with the experience of fear and anxiety associated with using personal technology:

**Andrea:** They can't afford not to be on it [the internet] but then they hear all the stories about it, particularly older people, and they get really nervous ... So people don't know how to do risk assessment I think a lot of the time and don't know how to do research. And if they do, a lot of people start believing conspiracies are scamming or whatever. So there's a huge amount of dis-information that didn't used to be there five or 10 years ago.

**Paul:** You touched on it when you were asking where can people go if they run into bother and the first thing I thought of as soon as you see that McAfee sort of security, people will freak out when they don't understand it.

Again this touches on the interconnected nature of digital and wider life skills including the personal financial management skills already discussed but also the ability to appropriately assess the options and risks inherently associated with using computing equipment and being online. This second point is discussed further in the Safeguarding section below.

Finally, and before considering user support, it is important to highlight that the definition of 'devices' is rapidly expanding to include emergent technologies and connected objects which can also be a source of unease for users. As Maria shared "*Oh Alexa, sometimes we're talking about something and then it's like, it's just things are popping up on [e.g. social media] and I'm just thinking "Is this thing proper spying?" I'm not sure I can know*".

## ACCESSIBILITY: USER SUPPORT

It was clear from this study, and brought into sharp relief by COVID-19, that support to enable and enhance digital inclusion for example: training courses, mentoring/buddying or assisted access has been mainly ad hoc, reliant on the good will of people 'on the ground' whether they are family, friends, teachers, mentors and an array of public and third sector workers and volunteers and ultimately dependant on individuals asking for or being identified as needing support.

**Paul:** *I went to lovely groups such as I think it's Action for Elders ... they are there to provide technology, and they will coach and get people online. With another gentleman I'm thinking about with a learning disability. He's got the smartphone, but he can't use that to its full use so I'm teaching him how to use YouTube, we've got him on to Zoom meetings in to connect with specific groups.*

**Sarah:** *This is it, you don't know until they come forward. How can you know until they ask for that help and you have to go by the individual circumstances, it's not a one size fits all. So, it's people asking "How do I make my type bigger because you know my eyesight's going. I can't get to the optician' and you know, it's accessibility.*

Users with lower levels of numeracy and literacy and/or other limitations such as English language proficiency or cultural constraints find that joining even entry level public training courses, such as those delivered via Further Education Colleges and other adult training and education providers is not possible. Therefore, even formal training when delivered is done so at the community level, whether that community in this instance is of place, peoples (shared values) or practice (shared lifestyles/experiences).

Talking about her experience as both a member and mentor of the asylum seeker and refugee community, Sally noted that what technical training was provided tended to be as 'pop-up' events within regular meetings. Delivered by third party organisations, these were often a part of a larger

event and therefore limited in scope to specific topics such as job searches and rarely, if ever, delivered in the audiences' first language(s).

## Families and Friends

Several participants felt that there was a general, and incorrect, assumption that if an individual was in regular contact with their family, or individual(s) who provide care and friendship, that they would be supported in using and learning about computers and the internet. However, family members may themselves only have limited knowledge, a situation which may be exasperated if the overall level of literacy in the family and community is low or as Sally describes below English is not your first language:

**Sally:** *Luckily, we have family that kind of understand or try to aid us but I had friends who English wasn't their parent's first language. And so even though it was a new concept for them, it was also for their parents too. So, when they struggled with like logging onto the computer their parents weren't able to assist them ... they all found it hard at first because then whenever there was difficulties, they couldn't reach out to anyone at home.*

Participants noted that it was unreasonable to expect family and friends to be available 'on demand' and recanted situations where without support, new users' motivation to use and learn waned quickly. Devices which became unused and eventually unusable and were then handed off to other family members or friends were mentioned frequently. However, support issues were of less concern than privacy issues. Two participants: Olivia speaking of her personal experience during COVID-19 and Vanessa in relation to one of her service clients, described how online access was linked strongly to unwanted encroachment personal privacy:

**Olivia:** *Like most people I have HAD to learn to use computers more. Still very unsure of what is ok to agree to via screens so always need children's help. So that takes away your own choice AND privacy. So the whole family needs to know what you are doing! ... I found it difficult not to be get cash out [due to isolating] and use it as I pleased. I have to tell my children to pay online and then for them to use my cashpoint cards. [Emphasis participant's own].*

**Vanessa:** *So some clients, they have a mobile phone because they absolutely have to have a mobile phone for text messages and stuff to remind them of their appointments but they come to us to read it and tell them [what it says] ... and it's usually because they're on drug and alcohol rehabilitation things and that's why they come to us because they don't want their neighbours reading that little 'pingy' message.*

This is not to say that family and close friends should be excluded from the support ecosystem but rather should be seen as allies and included in any information, training or other support provided. Paul, who works in a deprived neighbourhood, provided an example of how this can work, "I've come across a lady in her 50s with a learning disability, but keen to get online, so it's [me] working with the family. Financially they can fund this kit and she has a personal assistant involved who can educate her."



## Assisted Access

For participants who served lower socio-economic, generally white British communities, the digital divide was seen as a temporary state which will resolve itself overtime through education and training and as older generations pass away and younger, 'digital native', generations come through. However, this view was not universal and certainly those who worked with ethnic minorities including asylum seekers and refugees, and gypsy travellers, believed that there were always going to be members of their communities who would not be able to successfully operate online independently because of first or second language literacy and numeracy issues.

Discussing the current UK Government 'Digital First' strategy brought up a significant level of concern for Vanessa: *"So how many people do we lose along the way? I think it's a scary mentality. I don't think it's ever going to be every single person is going to be able to do this. Just like in 2021, not every single person can read and write"*.

Other participants, reiterating the necessity of one-on-one support, noted how difficult it had been to successfully replicate this type of support online during the COVID-19 pandemic as Ali pointed out *"You can't have a volunteer or a staff member necessarily sit there and go through the form with you and kind of talk to you about it and explain things."* and the high cost of providing this high level of personal support, in terms of time and resources as well as money, was evident:

**Andrea:** *But in terms of our area, people really need to be on it to get information, particularly for benefits and housing. A lot of organizations are now saying online only, which is discriminatory, obviously, but those that need help, it costs a lot of time and energy to help those that really need it ... it enhances and increases inequality and people then feel even more awkward, telling you that they're not on, that they wouldn't know how to.*

**Vanessa:** *We've got to set up policies to ensure that we're storing people's information correctly, because we're storing the National Insurance Number, we're storing their passwords, we're storing their email addresses. And it's a nightmare, let alone just the level of time it takes for staff, because you can't say to some of these clients, there's your computer, there's your information. We literally have to sit with them and do every single step.*

However, despite this high cost and as a number of participants noted, assisted access provided them with an important opportunity to connect with people, often those most in need of support and care beyond digital access, in a familiar, trusted and safe environment often with childcare or other activities to keep children occupied, and provide space to talk about their wider circumstances and wellbeing and any issues or support needs they may have.

## Supporter Support

One overlooked group, until the COVID-19 pandemic, are community-based workers and volunteers. As previously mentioned, many of these individuals are often in role due to their affinity to or membership of the ethnic minority or marginalised community they support, and as such they themselves live and work within varying degrees of digital exclusion. Vanessa explained the situation within her organisation at the start of the first full lockdown in March 2020: *"We've had to spend a fortune buying laptops for our staff ... and then we realised most of our staff couldn't use laptops"*.

This experience is not exceptional and as Ali commented: *"I'm sure they [volunteer befriender] might have helped with some of the technological issues but obviously, that's just going to be on a very simple explanatory level because, you know, us volunteers aren't experts in technology by any stretch of the imagination"*.

In only one of the participant's organisations was technology for volunteers a permanent budget item and one which was well funded, although it is important to note that 'digital' is a core capability and service for this organisation. Rather than a separate, 'bolt-on' strategy, it is fully integrated into all the organisation does. Nonetheless, Kyle raised an important point regarding volunteering today and while not applicable to all volunteer roles, there is still a tendency when calculating the cost of volunteers to, as he put it *"... budget for sandwiches and bus tickets"* rather than the cost of providing digital equipment and training and went on to explain:

**Kyle:** *So I think if you start incorporating tech into that, voluntary expenses can be quite expensive, you know, just kind of paying someone's occasional plan [internet access] you know, can work into the hundreds of pounds over the course of a year. So yeah, I think it's made us realize that digital exclusion has to be almost embedded within the organisation, in the same way that digital solutions and digital engagement has to be embedded with it. It's not something that's separate, or it's not something ... I mean, I think a lot of people will see the digital strategy is something which sits over here. Whereas we see it is completely embedded within the organisation that runs right through it.*

What was notable in its absence from this study was any significant discussion of formalised, public education and training via for example further education colleges or other adult or continuing education providers. Only one participant, Paul, mentioned this form of digital learning and development and he did so to highlight how inaccessible these options are for some people rather than to promote this type of support per se:

**Paul:** *But I think anything with regards to the University, York Learning, the [York] College for younger people or whoever, whatever demographic that fits, and if they would like to do that then that's there. It's just bearing in mind, everyone's life, different mobility, anxiety, and all the sorts of things that may impact.*

## Remembering the Individual

Expanding on the final comment above, the relationship between individual circumstances, personal choice, and digital engagement and inclusion was a repeating theme in this study. However, participant views varied in both the nature and validity of the underlying cause(s) of these.

In addition to the literacy and numeracy limitations presented above, Sarah noted that within the context of elderly people (although her comment is equally valid for all types of learning disabilities): “... you have people [asking] “Can you do it for me?” because they just don't want to deal with that side of things. It doesn't register because they have trouble learning things”. For others, it was a personal inability to overcome fear (of the unknown) linked with an ignorance of the benefits of online access and people not being prepared to continue trying and giving up:

**Andrea:** *So I think what you're coming up against is people's perceptions. So it's not that it's not available [learning and development support], it's that people themselves, have made their own decision about whether they're capable of doing things or not and they don't realise that being online can help.*

**Paul:** *I see folk without ability, without technology but they're happy as Larry and that's just the way it is ... So there'll be people that aren't fused either way that they can or cannot. Now the pandemic has shown us that maybe a few people do want to because we're in a world where the convenience came online ... So there's people who aren't really sure, there's people it will affect because the world's gone digital, and we can't get them to engage.*

The sense of COVID-19 having forced people to engage online ran throughout several of the conversations. This was not however accompanied by any strong sense of any previous ‘missing out’ or ‘loss’ conjunction and indeed some participants’ stories demonstrated increased interest in and confidence with online access, albeit one that was re- rather than pro-active.

While there was no evidence of the pandemic driving people to overcome a deeply embedded fear of the digital technologies covered in this study, the increased exposure, even if it was ‘forced’, to digital devices and services was seen to change beliefs around personal needs and capabilities and individual motivation to try or continue learning and practicing digital access skills.

Many participants felt their technical skills had improved during the pandemic because they had to for example, learn to use Zoom or shop online. There was a consistent view that online socialising, including gatherings where social contact is an important element if not the main purpose for example: worshipping or learning, was necessary during the pandemic and there was also a universal agreement that these were no substitute for in person meeting. Even where digital substitutions were made, many participants noted that after an initial wave of interest attendance fell off sharply and the events were put on-hold.

However, one person who is disabled noted that their life was improved by having online access during the pandemic. They were able to visit a museum online in London and to connect to new people online. This person hoped this would continue to be available post-pandemic. Another noted how business had to very quickly change how they do businesses and how much happier their husband was working from home. They hoped that the choice to work at home would remain post-pandemic.

Comments in this section highlight the difference between the states of learning to use technology and actually using that technology and the significant but often overlooked importance of social learning (discussed further below) and further, point to an opportunity for 'gentle persuasion' through less purposeful and more playful engagement with technology for example, introducing elements to already established and familiar recreational sessions.

## ONLINE SAFETY AND SAFEGUARDING

Increased digital inclusion does however inevitably lead to increased exposure to the negative impacts of online access. While all online users are exposed to cyber-threats such as viruses or identity threats, participants felt that ethnic minority and marginalised communities were particularly at risk, both when accessing online content and in internet enabled offline situations.

Anna and Sarah work in a deprived neighbourhood and both noted how poverty and a lack of opportunities made some members of their community, particularly but not exclusively younger people, highly susceptible to online marketing or offers and competitions and these individuals are very naïve in terms of the personal information that they hand over. Paul also observed this and noted that the 'street savvy' that many of his service users demonstrated offline did not follow them online and adeptly summarised the situation in his comment:

*Paul: The reality is that you're exposed and it's a brand new world. I remember when I first got online, it's massive, it's overwhelming ... and that risk is just magnified, because we know telephone scams are going on, we know people are door knocking and getting hard cash, or they get in, so these scams will always happen but that level of vulnerability online is cranked up I think and it's about, yeah, that safety layer, and minimizing risk of exploitation and abuse (Paul).*

Sarah further noted how difficult it was to keep up with online developments and how " *parents are trying to research as quickly as they can on different apps, and it's keeping up with that safety online, and mental health awareness as well.*" Mental health and general wellbeing concerns, particularly relating to children and young children, are unfortunately common and well reported. Concerns regarding the overuse of computer and internet use and the impact of this on health and social skills were raised by a number of participants particularly, as expressed by Maria, the 'insidious' nature of social media popularity and peer pressure.

In addition, Andrea voiced concerns over the increasing volume of and exposure of online users to adult, offensive or dangerous content and the increasing online abuse and harassment of women

and girls. While this again is not restricted to ethnic minority and marginalised communities, again poverty, low levels of education, insularity and precarity make these communities particularly vulnerable to both online and offline but internet driven or enabled abuses. Participants provided the following insight into the realities of their communities:

**Vanessa:** *These people could be taken advantage of so easily. We've had to demand that one gentleman sets up his own bank account, because he was being financially abused by a family member ... but even that process took like four weeks. Nothing's easy.*

**Andrea:** *You know, kids have got mobile phones, that there's someone that we know that she's been groomed, but then she has been abused of the family's been abused so you can see why it might be happening. So she's looking for something. That that's her learned behaviour.*

**Ali:** *In the hostels, they take away the mobile phones [of asylum seekers] in case they are being used in trafficking. Some charities give them new ones so they can contact their families, not in their language though.*

## SERVICE DESIGN AND PROVISION

There was a strong belief within the participant group that essential service providers, specifically in this context statutory social services such as housing, universal credit and employment, while adopting and implementing 'digital first' strategies fail to adequately train and support users of these services, which in turn generates problems which exasperate existing fears of technology.

Andrea particularly noted the complexity of these processes and how difficult they are for untrained, inexperienced and non-confident users saying "All the forms that they want people to do and things like if you're going to the Job Center, and you forget your Gmail account, they just give you another one, so if you don't know what you're doing ... they were sloppy in that, getting people to understand, because a lot of people now are scared of technology".

Many participants expressed a strong sense of frustration that policies, processes and systems are designed and implemented remotely, and by people they feel have little or no knowledge of the lived experiences of ethnic minority and marginalised groups in the UK and whose digital literacy is at a much higher level than many of their end users. This, it is felt, prevents truly accessible and inclusive services from being delivered and increasing the need for assisted access (discussed above) at the community level:

**Vanessa:** *... they come up with all these bright spark ideas that then fail because they've not thought it through, that the people that are most deprived, are way below where they think they are. So we've got those people that kind of have an idea how to use a [SMART] phone. That's a step nearer to everybody else, I guess, but can't do much other than the very basics. We've got a fewer people that can use a laptop and stuff ... and what do we do? Do we just let them sink further? ... We've been through this pain a number of times. Our clients don't*

*have email addresses, our clients don't have mobile phones, our clients don't have access to the internet to fill in their journal every day. They have to come to us to do that, we have to store their passwords, we have to set up email addresses for them and they don't seem to grasp that is real.*

## LOOKING FORWARD

This final section looks to the future and focuses on the priorities, preferences and ideas specifically expressed by the participants in this study with regards to maximising digital inclusion and reducing the digital divide for their communities, before presenting a small number of current, local initiatives.

## UPSKILLING AND SUPPORT

### Confident and Safe Use

As stated succinctly by Vanessa: “... we need better WiFi across the country that's not expensive for people”. Participants felt that a focus on city/town centre fast broadband investment in and role out, had been at the expense of inner- and sub-urban neighbourhoods resulting in slow and/or limited connectivity. However, improved infrastructure alone was considered insufficient. Participants noted a need for comprehensive, foundational public education as to how it all works: the internet, web services ('cloud') services and devices connected to it, before any further or more advanced training or support was provided.

However, it was recognised that underpinning confident and safe online use is the development of risk assessment skills and from this the application of good judgement and further, that this 'good judgement' includes the discipline to set and follow self-imposed limitations. The participants highlighted priority areas such as: sharing personal information, non-engagement with trolls and bullies, rejecting 'too good to be true' statements or offers and balancing the time spent on and off-line recreation and the development of inter-personal skills.

It was acknowledged however, that this was neither a simple or quick goal and needed to be instilled within the whole family/household rather than just the individual and as will all training and support provision requires tailoring to existing levels of learning skills, literacy and numeracy, and if delivered in English, first language being preferred but accepting that this is not always available, then second language proficiency.

## Integrated, Sustainable, Long-Term Solutions

Regardless of what initiatives are put in place, participants felt that 'one-off' interventions for example providing tablets or running a training course, were welcomed but on their own insufficient to significantly increase digital inclusion. Rather their preference is to be part of a proactive, long-term, sustainable and collaborative support system which is integrated with the development of wider life skills and flexible enough to work with individual circumstances. For example learning to use a desktop/laptop PC along as well as mobile devices, online safety and user wellbeing or social, low literacy and /or multilingual learning.

**Ali:** *What came up when we were doing some research with the York Human Rights City Network, was the idea of not just having one training session that people can come along to and leaving it but keeping supporting them with using the technology. So checking in on how they're doing if they've got any problems, because otherwise there might be a tendency for people to start using it, and then kind of give up and feel deflated, if they can't, you know, if they're not able to do a certain feature on the technology that they've been given.*

**Andrea:** *I think if you're going to get involved [in providing equipment], you have to do the training, you have to say, "How are you getting on?", "Have you got any viruses?", "what we've been clicking on?", because we've had that. When I did that digital inclusion thing originally, I had to get in a lady from Computer Start, first thing she'd do ... someone would bring a laptop in and say "I've got all these viruses", or "it's stuck", you know, so you need IT help and support for quite a while.*

Ideas put forward to achieve this included early intervention and family/household based education and training for example tailored parent and child(ren) programmes and 'in-community' apprenticeships, aligned with the culturally and/or socially specific needs and issues of that community. Its important to recognise that these will change overtime, for young people who have exited or have otherwise disrupted formal education to learn employability skills such as office based technologies, writing and sending emails or CVs, or data entry and management.

As one participant commented "When I know our kids are likely to be leaving school at 12 it's not good enough that they can just read and write. I want them to use a computer, I want them to know how to send a CV, send an invoice, set up an Excel sheet, you know, all those things that are a vital part of what life's going to be ... we need something that doesn't just put a mobile phone in a kid's hand but a fun and exciting way of learning this, you know how to compose an email."

## Access to Expertise

An important element in developing safe and confident users is their ability to access timely and accurate information for example around the latest cyber-threats such as viruses and phishing scams, training such as device management and maintenance, or user accessibility and online safety tools.

Participants felt that this should be a central, public funded service which might be accessed directly by user or via family/friends. However, in this study many participants saw this as a 'one stop' trusted, expert resource for their staff and volunteers, particularly within the context of assisted access, providing 'support for the supporters' and ensuring that everyone was working off the same information.

One participant, Paul, felt that this might also extend to accurate and timely consumer information for example the latest affordable data plans and social tariffs, without having to resort to online comparison sites or other time-consuming market research. Another, related idea was that this expertise might be applied to the creation of innovative social services such as using the 'buying power' of a Local Authority organisation to negotiate low cost broadband and mobile services and building these into social housing rental costs.

## More than Mobile

Several participants raised concerns with the rapid up take and dominance of smartphones and the associated increase in 'mobile first' strategies. While understanding the attraction of relative low cost and convenience of mobile smartphones, these participants felt that there was a significant gap in knowledge and skills relating to the use of other technologies, such as desktop/laptops and office applications such as word processors, spreadsheets and even creative packages and somewhat unsurprisingly that this was very prevalent in young people:

**Vanessa:** *I mean, they [young adults] can sit on TikTok till the cows come home, they can send Tweets and WhatsApp and whatever else, but to send an email, it's almost like it's scary for them ... because the idea of composing an email is just very foreign and these are kids who have grown up with a mobile phone and their hands.*

**Maria:** *For daily needs a smartphone is fine but for actual school and work you need a proper computer, like a laptop, which can have video conferencing, and you should be able to do bigger things with that, and to share data and stuff, you need fast broadband ... So there's challenges and then there's people who have who can't afford any of it.*



It was felt that this had significant impact on the extent to which members of their community could access online social, including digital, support, learning and employment opportunities, take part in collaborative projects and successfully complete everyday tasks such filling in forms and submitting supporting documents.

All of these are accessible via mobile devices but not easily especially when working in a second language or with limited dexterity or vision. The user experience is often poor, a global issue known as 'experience poverty', which again may increase user anxiety and uptake.

**Vanessa:** *If we're going to go this way then it needs a hell of a lot of thought put into how do we get young people ready for the real world ... Every job I know ... if you're a hairdresser it's very likely your POS is a computer. You have to understand the computer to order and you order online now rather than by phone, so I don't understand why we haven't done more. Why have we never had a strategy that shows how people can use the actual computer, to do what the computer was invented for which is not to search for memes of cats but to write emails and track changes. It just blows my mind.*

**Kyle:** *For some people, especially young homeless people, the only thing they will own is a mobile phone, or a smartphone but actually, that doesn't allow us to do work in the way that you know ... we sit at a laptop and do work or, or even join meetings like we're doing now ... You can do it [on smartphone] but it's not same ... you're still kind of excluded in some respects, because you're not fully able to kind of access things like chats, and all that kind of thing.*

However, as Kyle noted, initiatives to increase digital inclusion are often made on assumptions rather than evidence of what is needed resulting in programmes that focus on device and data provision and very basic, entry level skills development. Discussing his work with people experiencing homelessness, he felt that this attitude resulted in them being, in his own words: 'disempowered' and 'infantilised'.

These examples suggest that to ensure that digital inclusion programmes and support are 'fit for purpose' it is important that their providers, local, regional or national, co-design services in conjunction with individual ethnic minority and marginalised communities to fully understand their issues and needs.

Two of the participant's organisations already run public cultural competency training courses (on hold at the time of writing) and all said that they would welcome the opportunity to share information about their communities.

## MAKING CHANGE HAPPEN

***Vanessa:** Yeah, but if you want change you have to do it, don't you? You can't just expect change ... We just have to do it, we can't sit back and hope ... and we do need spaces that people can come to that are nice and pleasant and can just sit and access the WiFi if they need to and commercial properties aren't going to do that so I think it will be down to the Third Sector working with Local Authorities to make that happen.*

Vanessa's comment above epitomises both the experience and attitude of those working and living in ethnic minority and marginalised communities whose needs are not being fully met by mainstream provisioning and 'one-size-fits-all' processes and technologies but it also foregrounds the ownership of and commitment for change and improvements expressed during this study (examples of current initiative are provided in the Local Innovations section below).

There was a strong intent amongst the participants towards collaboration, between themselves as community based organisations, and between this network, Local Authority staff and other local or regional support and development providers:

***Sarah:** I think it needs a collaborative approach with everybody in seminars and thinking "Right how do we tackle this?" rather than the few organisations that do tackle it. And then everybody can work together to get that demographic. So people can sit with people to show them the programs [applications], access to computers. I mean, with the spatial distance, the library sector can only offer so much. So, it is looking at the home learning and what they've got access to.*

***Paul:** Let's get everybody ... we've all got this common goal, and we can all work together to achieve it and a big part of this local area coordination is relationships, bringing people together. So that all fits in beautifully with how we like to work. So it's nice to see it happening really.*

However, this genuine commitment to change was tempered with realism. Participants acknowledge that as the UK moves beyond the pandemic, digital exclusion is just one of many issues in ethnic minority and marginalised communities which will need addressing. Resources, human and otherwise, are finite and digital inclusion initiatives will be competing for these against increasingly poor outcomes of for example, housing and social care, health and education.

In addition, it would be incorrect to assume that every third sector, community based organisation considered the closure of the digital divide to be within their remit. As two of the organisations in this study emphasised, they "were not that kind of organisation". If in their everyday work they came across an individual or household that was obviously struggling with online tasks or not being able to access the internet, they would offer as much immediate assistance as possible, they would then look to make a referral to another support service.

This should not be misinterpreted as some organisations being unwilling to take on the task of digital inclusion but rather an acknowledgement of the existing, informal or semi-formal third sector and Local Authority support network. In this growing and developing network, specific community

frontline support for example, third sector organisations who work with gypsy traveller, refugee or elderly communities, work alongside and action referrals from public sector individuals and teams such as Local Area Coordinators and GP Link workers. The ethos here being, as Paul explained, if a person is connected to one person in the network, they are connected to all.

## LOCAL INITIATIVES

### Restore: Person-Centred ‘Whole of Life’ Approach to Individual Learning and Development

<https://www.restoreyork.co.uk/>

Founded in 2010, Restore (York)’s primary aim is to provide accommodation and support for individuals experiencing homelessness in the city of York, for whatever reason. Today Restore provides accommodation and support for up to 39 adults in 11 properties, some owned and others rented from private landlords or trusts with complementary aims and values.

However, the attitude, approach, and outcomes of Restore set their initiative apart. Taking a person-centred approach, starting from whatever point in life each individual is at, Restore’s aim goes significantly further than their residents’ immediate safety and support, although this is vital.

Recognising a lack of positive social relationships and long term social exclusion and isolation, stable community living, learning – including digital and other life and employability skills – recreation and contribution creates the foundation for ‘whole of life’ development of individuals, matched to their individual needs and at their individual pace, and continuing until individuals have the skills and confidence to live and work independently.

### Public Living Room: Affordable, Supported and Private Access

<https://www.camerados.org/>

Public Living Room is a new initiative being piloted across the city and developed in York by local members of the international Camerados movement, which promotes mutual aid through grassroots action in the real world and online, and who are also members of the York Multiple Complex Needs (MCN) Network.

The Camerados movement is described by its Founder as: *"... human spaces for folk to be alongside each other during the good times and the tough. They are places to meet new people, have a chat and a cuppa with no agendas, no outcomes, a place where you had permission to be rubbish? It's amazing what happens when you come in without the intention of trying to fix people. People often have the answers themselves."*

As one of the York organisers, and a participant in this study, explained further:

**Vanessa:** ... *the idea that I want for [my organisation] is that you come and have a coffee, a place where people don't have to pay a fiver to access WiFi and stuff and could just sit and feel safe ... a place where people with disabilities could access it easily within the city and feel welcome. Yeah, I definitely want this and part of that is building two 'Zoom rooms'. I didn't come up with that name, but we'll build two, small private rooms with a table and a couple of chairs where people can have consultations in person or on-line, in private.*

## The Digital Inclusion Lab: From Digital Exclusion to Digital Literacy & Leadership

<http://www.goodorganisation.co.uk/>

Good Organisation's 'Digital Inclusion Lab' initially sought to ensure that individuals affected by homelessness within York had access to connective technology during the early stages of the coronavirus pandemic in 2020. The project offered practical resources ranging from solar powered backpacks (allowing rough sleepers to recharge their phones), through to the provision of mobile devices, software and basic IT training.

The initiative has grown, and it now provides a supportive environment where homeless people can acquire a variety of skills and knowledge related to digital systems; from basic foundation level computer literacy to app development, coding and the application of proximity based technology.

To date the Digital Inclusion Lab has produced:

- a) Audible York, a digital heritage trail app developed by local homeless people, which presents history from a variety of different social perspectives,
- b) SoundByte, a micro-heritage project combining badge designs from the past, with embedded technology,
- c) Keychain, part of a city-wide support framework which empowers homeless people to self-manage the information they wish to share with volunteers and street outreach workers and
- d) LEx Talks, a dynamic media resource incorporating interactive videos as part of a training toolkit, where conditional branching is used to demonstrate different outcomes based on the decisions made by service providers when dealing with individuals with complex needs.

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